



Pillar of strength: Bakenga's sister proudly stands alongside former Italy international Giorgio Chiellini, holding the Marcus Rashford Award. She accepted the honour on Bakenga's behalf while he was away fulfilling his ISL duties. [INSTAGRAM / @MBAKENG](#)

He continues because he feels a responsibility. "There's so much to fix in Congo. There are so many children who have nothing. I can't express the feeling of knowing that some child's life is worth nothing just because they were born in the wrong place. Every child deserves a fair opportunity in life," he says.

Inspired by his uncle

Bakenga's activism might seem to be inspired by his uncle's, and indeed, some of his teammates have joked that he's trying to win a Nobel prize of his own. He readily admits this isn't the case, saying that his work is just a shadow of what his uncle has done. "My uncle is probably the greatest human being I know. He's incredibly sharp. He can meet you today, and even if he sees you

again five years later, he'll remember your name, your family's name, and your entire history. If you visit his hospital in Congo, he'll meet a woman and know exactly when she came to the hospital, who is left in her family, and how many surgeries he performed on her. It's both scary and impressive, but it also shows how much he cares about everyone he meets. The work he does is emotionally draining, but he still knows how to be funny. I talk to him at least once a week, and we just joke around and have fun. He'll say the smartest thing ever, and then go back to joking. Before I came to India, I spoke to him about playing football here. He was very happy for me. He likes Indians a lot because he's worked with many in Congo. He told me, 'Yeah, they are very smart, and you will love them. They are very similar to us'. He joked that I should have grown up in India's heat instead of Norway's cold because he says the cold has made me a 'white person'," says Bakenga. While his uncle convinced him to stick with football when he was on the verge of quitting, his words also encouraged

Bakenga to explore the world in a way he hadn't before. "I was happy playing football in Europe, but after our conversation, I started to consider exploring the world. That's how I ended up going to Japan to play in the J League. It's also why, when I got the chance to come to India, I took it rather than going to yet another country in Europe. I've never been here, and I wanted to see the place. I want to earn money to help run my school, but I also want to experience new cultures," he says.

This isn't to say Bakenga only sees his time in India as a way to earn money. "I'm someone who gives 100 per cent to my club. I really want the team to do well. If I'm in India, I want to make a mark here. This doesn't mean I have no interest in football – it's a part of my life too. My goal here is to help the team as much as I can. Every day, I talk to the younger players on the team and try to help them personally and professionally," he says. However, Bakenga admits his ultimate goal will eventually take him back to Congo. "Football is important, but I see it as a tool for a greater mission, which is to educate children. Right now, what gives me the most happiness in life is the work I do with the schools. Compared to my football career, that brings me far more joy. I love going back to Congo and seeing how I'm able to change the lives of these kids. Already, some of the children have gone to college. Several have come back and are now contributing to the community. I expected they would want to stay in the big cities, but instead, they've returned to help and improve their villages," Bakenga says.

"I know I'm a small person who has accomplished very little compared to what my uncle and others in my family have done. No matter what I do, I don't think I'll ever be able to match their work. It's just something I have to accept, and I'm fine with it. As long as I can make a difference in one person's life, that's enough for me. I've been blessed in so many ways. I don't know if I deserve it. When I think about it, it doesn't make any sense. The least I can do is pay it forward," he says.